

other than Bhutan rank in the bottom quarter of emerging markets and developing economies. It is such a source of untapped potential. If these women could enter the labour market and be productively employed, Viksit Bharat 2047 would be within reach. We estimate if South Asian women worked at the same rate as South Asian men, the GDP could be up to one half higher. Now you ask why? There is a whole range of reasons. One is societal norms. There are just not enough jobs, especially the type that women in most other

in services. They tend to work in agriculture and construction. If this is the kind of job that women usually have, maybe it's no surprise that there is this marriage penalty.

We have shown in household level data that upon marriage, 12% of women drop out of the labour force. And perhaps this is in part, a reflection of the types of jobs that women commonly do in South Asia.

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You have spoken about how women need to have productive jobs. The Periodic Labour

important obstacle?

It comes to the question of which policy should be implemented. I suspect there is no single policy that will be effective in isolation. If you just change all the social norms so suddenly everyone is very happy to encourage women to work, you would also not get a huge impact if you didn't have adequate jobs. It's a matter of aggregate employment. There just needs to be more jobs. That's not a question about women and men. Everything has to come together. That's what happened in Saudi Arabia also—jobs were

be easier if social norms were more welcoming. There's one interesting thing about social norms. It seems that, in principle, there's readiness for greater female labour force participation. According to a World Bank-Facebook Survey on Gender Equality at Home, only about 42% of people think that men should be the main breadwinners. This is an issue of social perceptions and we think that everyone else around us is conservative. When we asked people what others think about who should be the main breadwinner, 63% were in favour of men being the breadwinner. So there is a groundswell of acceptance that women can be the main breadwinners but can this translate into jobs is the question.

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If recommended measures are implemented, how long would a structural shift take?

In Saudi Arabia, it took about five years. They started in 2017 when the female LFPR was about 21% and by 2022 it was 32%. And this was proper employment. We don't know how good it was compared to male employment, but it was a significant increase within five years. But it also took the effort of all of the economy and the society. If it's achievable in Saudi Arabia, then why wouldn't it be achievable in South Asia as well? BT

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countries have. For example, the share of female employment in export industries is about three times as high as that in non-tradeable sectors. But export industries are small. The region also ranks somewhere near the bottom—almost all countries in the region rank in the bottom quartile by trade-to-GDP ratios.

Another sector that employs women in other countries is services. So again, services sectors are small in South Asia, except in Sri Lanka, the Maldives, and Bhutan. But even if they were larger, there is an additional obstacle—it seems that in South Asia, women don't tend to work

Force Survey data suggests that even though female LFPR has risen in India, a lot of it is in self employment. What is the way forward?

It is reassuring that female LFPR is growing but if it were growing in more productive jobs, rather than just agriculture [and] unpaid family work, that would be even better. The whole economy should shift towards non-agricultural employment, and that will drive up wages, and per capita incomes.

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The report has highlighted several factors that hinder higher female LFPR. What is the most

there, the laws changed and the social norms began to change. It all came together to increase female LFPR.

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Do you think a quota for women employment is needed?

I suspect it will take more than quotas. It will require improvements on labour demand, more job creation in general, and job creation in sectors that typically employ women. It will also require labour supply and laws—although India doesn't rank poorly on the laws, it's more about implementation. And then, of course, everything would